The ‘unjust and unwarrantable action’ was the cause of the violence and bloodshed.[66]

Writing from far-off London, the organ of the Indian National Congress, *India*, echoed this view:

> Tuticorin … is the stronghold of the Swadeshi movement in Southern India, and ever since the starting of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company at Tuticorin, to compete with the British Indian Steam Navigation Company, which had hitherto enjoyed the monopoly of traffic between Tuticorin and Colombo, there has been trouble of some sort or other between the people on the one side and the representatives of European commerce and the authorities on the other.

The rivalry between SSNCo and BI was common knowledge. ‘[T]he prosperity of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Co. has materially affected the commercial interest of the B.I.S.N. Co. cannot be denied.’ Unsurprisingly therefore BI had ‘a grievance against the S.S.N.Co’. Given that ‘Mr V.O. Chidambaram Pillai is the life and soul of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Co’, ‘[a]t the present juncture, to strike a blow at him virtually means a deathblow to the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Co’. And, this was precisely what the government did. ‘It has been made very evident that where Anglo-Indian and Indian commercial enterprise come in conflict, the bureaucrat’s boasted impartiality cuts a very poor figure. And if the bureaucrat ceases to be impartial, what business has he to be in India at all?’[67]

VOC put the onus on BI when the government prosecuted him for the violence: ‘This case has been cooked up against me by the executive officers of Tuticorin and Tinnevelly at the instigation of some of the European merchants of Tuticorin who suffered a heavy loss of their business and earnings on account of my work for the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company and some other Swadeshi enterprises at Tuticorin.’[68] Similarly, in her petition to the King-Emperor pleading for clemency on VOC’s behalf, his wife Meenakshi argued that ‘the case had its origin in the rivalry between the two steam navigation companies in Tuticorin’.[69]